

Namaste GOODBYE

Shivraj Patil

Shivraj Patil must have had implicit faith in Murphy's law which states that "whatever can go wrong will go wrong". As Union home minister when the country suffered the worst terror attacks in living memory, his conduct became a symbol of all that was wrong with the UPA Government. Since Patil took charge at North Block, there have been over 6,000 terrorist attacks in India, big and small, resulting in nearly 2,000 deaths. Each time innocents fell victims to terrorists' bullets and bombs, Patil had a ready fig leaf: there are less deaths now than during the previous BJP-led NDA government. Had he been as obsessed with his job as he was with his looks—he was often called the Serial Dresser for changing his attire three to four times a day—the toll perhaps would have been even less. Barring a handful, few have any insight about how the UPA works. Yet, it is often said that had Patil won the Lok Sabha election in 2004, the loyalist in him was the Family's first choice for prime minister. For averting that disaster, the voters of Latur deserve the country's gratitude.

by Ashok Damodaran



NARENDRA BISHT

Each time innocents fell victims to terrorists, Patil's defence was that more people died during the NDA regime.

Roller Coaster RIDER

Ratan Tata

For the very private person that he is, 2008 has been a very public roller coaster ride. Beginning with the rock star applause at the Nano rollout in January, Tata has created news and been chased by headlines. Post Corus, lesser entrepreneurs would have been daunted but globalisation is a matter of conviction not convenience for Tata. Even as he was wrapped up in the acquisition of Jaguar and Land Rover, the shy titan was drawn into an ugly public battle in Singur. Refusing to be blackmailed, he pulled out to relocate in Gujarat. The respite from headlines though was typically brief as terrorists struck Mumbai and almost destroyed the 103-year-old Taj Hotel. While reopening the hotel last week, he said "We can be hurt but we cannot be knocked out." To many it is enough to do things right. For Tata, leadership means doing the right things. So what if the ride is a roller coaster.

by Shankkar Aiyar



HEMANT CHAWLA